Chapter 11

Task F: Hotwiring the Storefront

Our customer wants us to make the storefront more interactive. After we ask her what she means, we come to realize that what she wants is for the page to update in place—no bouncing between pages, but to have the page dynamically update as the cart is being filled.

Back in the old days (up until 1994 or so), browsers were treated as dumb devices. When you wrote a browser-based application, you'd send stuff to the browser and then forget about that session. At some point, the user would fill in some form fields or click a hyperlink, and your application would get woken up by an incoming request. It would render a complete page back to the user, and the whole tedious process would start afresh. That's exactly how our Depot application behaves so far.

But it turns out that browsers aren't really that dumb. (Who knew?) They can run code. All modern browsers can run JavaScript. And it turns out that the JavaScript in the browser can interact behind the scenes with the application on the server, updating the stuff the user sees as a result.

New with Rails 7 is a collection of web frameworks included by default that collectively go by the name Hotwire,[52] which stands for HTML Over The Wire. Clever, huh? The general idea is that instead of always building entire HTML pages to send to the client, you build HTML fragments or partials and send the results to the client, which will integrate those fragments into the page that already is being displayed.